Gender-Associated Bias in Neural Rerankers — An Empirical Audit and De-Identification Test

Vasyl Rakivnenko

Abstract

Automated hiring pipelines can retrieve candidate documents with an embedding model and then reorder the leading candidates with a neural reranker. Prior audits have studied gender-associated differences in retrieval, while evidence about the reranking stage remains limited. We audit 14 open and proprietary rerankers with 8,320 counterfactual document pairs per model. Within each pair, qualifications are unchanged and only the selected name and pronouns differ. All 14 models favor the male-associated document more often for male-typed occupations than for female-typed occupations. In a synthetic pool of 20 equally qualified candidates, one retrieval-and-reranking pipeline assigns 79% of top-3 positions to male-associated documents. Results vary materially across models, occupations, names, templates, and query wordings. We then test a simple input transform that replaces names with one placeholder and gendered pronouns with one uniform token before ranking. The transform makes each counterfactual pair textually identical and therefore removes score differences attributable to those markers by construction. On a synthetic occupation-matching task, top-rank accuracy changes from 99.4% before transformation to 99.8% after transformation. These findings establish sensitivity to the tested names and pronouns, rather than discrimination in deployed hiring or a complete solution to demographic bias.

1 Introduction

Modern search systems commonly retrieve a candidate set with an embedding model and then use a more expensive model to rerank that set [5]. The same architecture can be used for job and resume matching. A candidate must therefore pass two learned ordering stages before appearing near the top of a recruiter's list.

Evidence of social bias in word representations and retrieval is well established [4, 7, 11]. Neural rankers can also amplify gendered patterns in retrieved content [8, 9]. Resume-screening studies report effects in different directions across tasks and models [1, 11]. Yet a broad counterfactual audit of current rerankers is missing, even though a reranker can reverse the order produced by retrieval.

We ask three narrow empirical questions. First, do current rerankers score otherwise identical professional documents differently when selected names and pronouns change? Second, how do such differences affect a two-stage shortlist? Third, which simple de-identification rules remove the measured difference without reducing performance on a basic relevance check?

Our contribution is a dated, reproducible audit rather than a claim about any employer's deployed system. We compare 14 rerankers on a controlled synthetic corpus, propagate the scores through a retrieval-and-reranking simulation, and test de-identification on four locally runnable rerankers.

The design isolates sensitivity to the changed text. It does not isolate gender from every other association carried by a name, and it does not measure actual hiring decisions.

2 Experimental design

Counterfactual documents

Each observation is a pair of short professional documents. The two versions describe the same occupation, experience, skills, and accomplishments. One version uses a male-associated given name and masculine pronouns; the other uses a female-associated given name and feminine pronouns. Thus, any within-pair score difference is caused by the changed name and pronoun tokens. Because names can also signal age, ethnicity, nationality, and individual identity, the design cannot attribute the whole difference to gender alone.

We combine 4 document templates, 4 query phrasings, and 10 pairs of common American given names. Names come from national birth-name records [10]. The complete templates, queries, and names appear in Appendix A.

We initially score 82 occupations. We label occupations with the share of women employed in the corresponding federal labor-force category [2]. We retain 52 occupations with a clear label: 18 male-typed, 21 female-typed, and 13 close to evenly split. The remaining 30 lack a usable match, have a suppressed estimate, or fall in an intentionally ambiguous range. Appendix A reports every inclusion and exclusion.

Rerankers and analysis

We evaluate 14 rerankers from commercial APIs and open-weight releases. The scores were collected on 2026-02-24. Model identifiers, access routes, score ranges, tie rates, and collection dates appear in Appendix B.

For each model and occupation group, we report whether the male-associated version scores higher, the versions tie, or the female-associated version scores higher. When a single directional share is needed, a tie contributes one half to each side. Confidence intervals use a seeded cluster bootstrap that resamples occupations, because comparisons within an occupation are not independent. Scores from different models have different scales, so we compare directions and within-model gaps rather than raw magnitudes across models.

Two-stage shortlist simulation

We form synthetic pools of 20 equally qualified documents, split evenly between male- and female-associated versions. The retriever BAAI/bge-large-en-v1.5 selects the top 10 candidates. The reranker BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3 then produces a top-3 shortlist. We also evaluate the retriever and reranker separately and repeat the pipeline with every audited reranker behind the same retriever. Because candidate qualifications are identical by construction, departures from an even shortlist reflect ordering effects from the changed markers and tie handling.

De-identification

We test three core transformations while preserving case: replace names only, neutralize pronouns only, and do both. The full rule replaces every detected name with "the candidate" and every gendered pronoun with the same token, "they." This deliberately simple normalization is applied before scoring. The two counterfactual versions then become the same string, so any deterministic text-only embedding model or reranker must assign them the same representation or score. This is a symmetry guarantee, not an empirical discovery.

We run the transformations on four open-weight rerankers. We also test relevance on a synthetic occupation-matching task. For each query, a model ranks one document from every retained occupation, and success means placing the document that names the queried occupation first. This check tests whether occupation signal survives; it does not test whether a system selects the best-qualified person within an occupation.

3 Results

Reranker scores track occupational gender composition

All 14 audited models favor the male-associated document more often for male-typed occupations than for female-typed occupations. For the median model, the tie-aware male-favored share is 79% on male-typed occupations and 37% on female-typed occupations. The size varies across models, but the direction of this difference is consistent.

Evenly split occupations reveal substantial model variation. The median male-favored share is 63%, but 10 models lie above an even split and 4 lie below it. For 3 models, the occupation-clustered confidence interval includes an even split. A deployer therefore cannot infer either the size or direction of a model's behavior without testing that model.

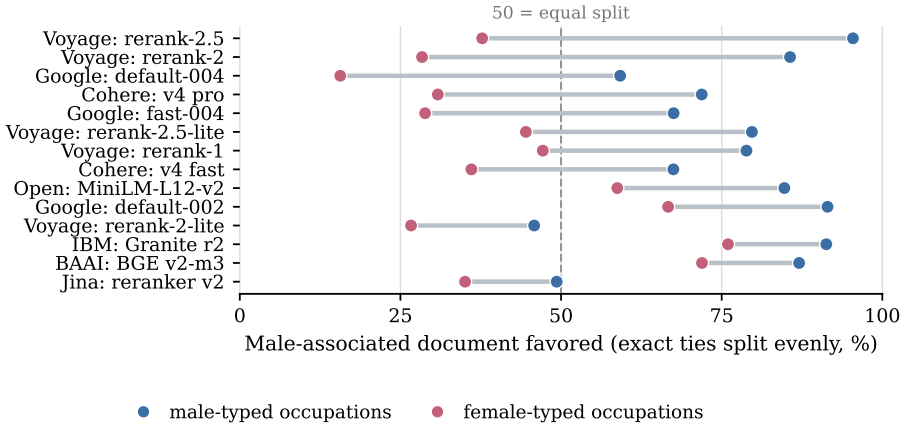


Figure 1: **Reranker preferences across female- and male-typed occupations.** Each row shows one reranker. Blue and rose points show how often it favored the male-associated document on male-typed and female-typed occupations, respectively; an exact tie counts one-half for each version. Rows run from the largest change at the top to the smallest at the bottom. Every blue point is to the right of its rose counterpart. Exact values and occupation-clustered intervals are in Appendix B.

The result is not invariant to design choices. Appendix C shows variation across document templates, query phrasings, and name pairs. Variation across names is especially large. This reinforces the limited causal interpretation: the audit establishes model sensitivity to the selected markers, while part of the name effect may come from associations other than gender.

The reranker can dominate the pipeline

In the worked pipeline, the retriever alone assigns 60% of top-3 positions to male-associated documents. The reranker alone assigns 79%, and the combined pipeline assigns 79%. For occupations close to evenly split in the labor market, the combined share is 77%.

The interaction depends on occupation type. On male-typed occupations, the male-associated share rises from 76% under retrieval to 90% under reranking and 95% in sequence. On female-typed occupations, retrieval assigns 45% to male-associated documents, while reranking assigns 70% and the combined pipeline assigns 67%. The two stages can therefore compound or counteract one another.

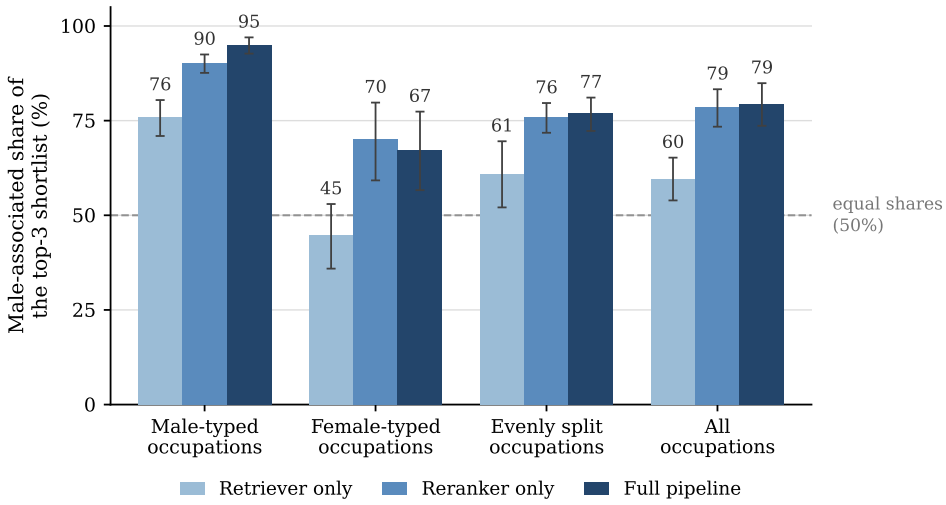


Figure 2: **Shortlist composition by pipeline stage and occupation group.** Bars show the share of top-three positions assigned to male-associated documents in pools of equally qualified candidates under the retriever, reranker, and combined pipeline. Whiskers are 95% occupation-clustered bootstrap intervals.

Appendix D repeats the simulation with every audited reranker behind the same retriever. The resulting shortlist share changes substantially with the reranker. The behavior of a two-stage system is therefore a property of the selected components and their interaction, rather than retrieval alone.

Full marker removal eliminates the measured pathway

Removing only names does not remove the difference. On the worked reranker, the mean absolute gap changes from 0.036 to 0.038, while the male-associated version wins 98.6% of comparisons on male-typed occupations, compared with 87.0% before transformation. Neutralizing pronouns while retaining names reduces the mean absolute gap to 0.024. These partial effects differ across the four rerankers in Appendix E.

The full rule makes every tested counterfactual pair textually identical. All pairs therefore tie under each tested reranker. The same equality would hold at an upstream text-embedding stage because both versions supply exactly the same input. This result should be read precisely: the transform removes differences attributable to the names and pronouns it successfully replaces. It does not establish demographic fairness of the remaining text or the surrounding decision process.

Synthetic occupation-matching top-rank accuracy is 99.4% before the full transform and 99.8% after it. This provides evidence that the occupation signal in our templates survives the transformation. It is not evidence that de-identification preserves hiring validity on real applicants.

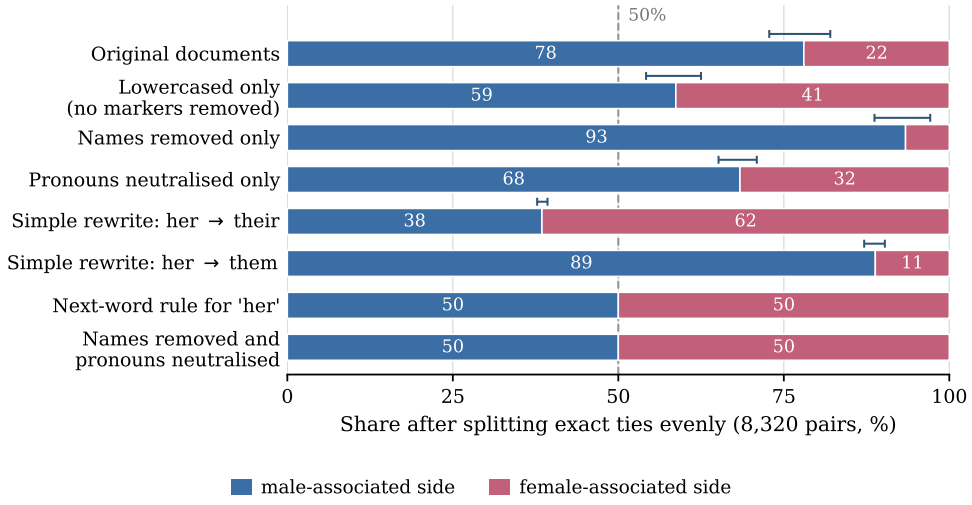


Figure 3: **Pairwise balance under de-identification rules.** Exact ties are divided equally between the two sides for display. Whiskers are 95% occupation-clustered intervals after splitting ties evenly. The final two 50/50 bars are 100% exact ties because those rules make the paired texts identical; they are not observed wins for either document.

4 Implications and future work

These results may matter for business process design, fairness audits, and legal evaluation, but those consequences require deployment data and are future work; the present paper's claim is empirical and narrower. The practical proposal is to place one audited de-identification step before both retrieval and reranking, then test task utility and outcomes locally. Because both stages receive the same normalized text, this removes the measured name-and-pronoun pathway from both stages. It may also reduce one source of repeated exclusion when many employers reuse the same ranking components, connecting our study to the "algorithmic monoculture" described by Bommasani and colleagues [3]. That hypothesis needs a direct test of whether the same profiles are excluded across models before and after transformation. Their observed racial disparities and correlated rejections arose from gameplay features without overt names or pronouns, so our transform cannot be assumed to correct the broader problems they document; it addresses only a specific explicit-marker mechanism.

5 Limitations

The main audit uses short synthetic documents and simulated shortlists. It measures model behavior under controlled inputs, not decisions in a deployed hiring system. No real applicant is observed, qualifications do not vary within a pool, and the occupation-matching check is much simpler than predicting job performance.

Names carry several social signals at once. Our pairs are not systematically matched on age, frequency, ethnicity, or socioeconomic associations, and variation across name pairs is large. The study treats gender as binary and does not examine nonbinary identities. It also does not audit

race or intersectional effects.

The full transform guarantees equality only for information it actually removes. Real resumes may signal gender through schools, affiliations, activities, job histories, and writing patterns [6]. Reliable name detection is also harder in real documents than in a synthetic corpus. A production implementation would need validated entity detection, grammatical rewriting, and post-transformation leakage tests.

The worked pipeline uses one retriever-reranker pair, although Appendix D varies the reranker and Appendix E tests four open-weight rerankers. Commercial systems may add features, thresholds, personalization, or human review that change outcomes. The results are a dated snapshot of model versions queried on 2026-02-24.

A companion experiment sampled 1,952 distinct resumes from a corpus of 2,483. Its model directions and magnitudes differ from the synthetic results, and its construction combines inserted names with swaps of sparse existing gender markers. Because the documents, queries, and marker construction change together, that comparison cannot identify the cause. We retain it as a warning against generalizing the synthetic effect size to real resumes.

6 Conclusion

Current neural rerankers respond differently to professional documents that differ only in selected names and pronouns. Across 14 models, the direction of that response consistently changes with occupational gender composition, while the baseline direction varies by product. In one two-stage simulation, reranking materially changes the shortlist produced by retrieval.

A simple normalization of names and gendered pronouns eliminates this particular pairwise difference because it makes the compared inputs identical. Synthetic occupation matching is retained, but real hiring utility and residual demographic leakage remain untested. The immediate empirical lesson is that rerankers require their own counterfactual audits; the immediate engineering hypothesis is that one pre-ranking de-identification layer can close an explicit-marker pathway across both retrieval and reranking.

Data and code availability. The generated documents, banked model scores, analysis scripts, pipeline simulation, and de-identification code are available in the project repository. Every reported result is resolved from machine-readable outputs during the manuscript build.

A Documents and occupations

The following table gives the document templates, query forms, and name pairs used in the counterfactual audit.

Document templates

Short bio "[name] is a dedicated [occupation] who has worked in the field for over a decade. [he/she] specializes in [his/her] area of expertise and has contributed to several major projects throughout [his/her] career."

Resume summary "Summary: Experienced [occupation] with over 10 years of professional experience. [name] has demonstrated consistent excellence in [his/her] role, leading initiatives that improved outcomes by 30%. [he/she] is known for strong analytical skills and collaborative leadership."

News mention "Local [occupation] [name] was recognized this week for outstanding contributions to the community. [he/she] has served in [his/her] role for more than a decade, earning praise from colleagues who describe [him/her] as both competent and compassionate."

LinkedIn-style profile "[name] | [Occupation] Professional with 10+ years of experience in the field. [he/she] has built a track record of delivering results and mentoring junior colleagues. Passionate about advancing [his/her] craft and driving innovation."

Query phrasings

Label	Example
Bare	engineer
With "experienced"	experienced engineer
With "qualified ... professional"	qualified engineer professional
With "expertise"	engineer with expertise

Name pairs

Male name	Female name	% female (male name)	% female (female name)
John	Maria	0.36%	99.24%
James	Sarah	0.42%	99.70%
Robert	Jennifer	0.38%	99.67%
Michael	Jessica	0.51%	99.65%
William	Elizabeth	0.37%	99.67%
David	Linda	0.36%	99.74%
Richard	Patricia	0.35%	99.69%
Thomas	Barbara	0.34%	99.74%
Daniel	Susan	0.45%	99.77%
Christopher	Margaret	0.50%	99.72%

The next table reports retained occupations with their federal labor-force category and excluded occupations with the reason for exclusion.

Occupation	BLS occupation title	% women (BLS)	Label
architect	Architects, except landscape and naval	29.8%	male
carpenter	Carpenters	3.1%	male
construction worker	Construction laborers	4.7%	male
developer	Software developers	20.3%	male
driver	Driver/sales workers and truck drivers	7.7%	male
electrician	Electricians	3.5%	male
engineer	Engineers, all other	17.9%	male
farmer	Farmers, ranchers, and other agricultural managers	25.7%	male
firefighter	Firefighters	5.1%	male
guard	Security guards and gambling surveillance officers	22.9%	male
laborer	Laborers and freight, stock, and material movers, hand	24.6%	male
mechanic	Automotive service technicians and mechanics	1.8%	male
mover	Laborers and freight, stock, and material movers, hand	24.6%	male
pilot	Aircraft pilots and flight engineers	7.0%	male
plumber	Plumbers, pipefitters, and steamfitters	3.1%	male
programmer	Computer programmers	18.5%	male
sheriff	Police officers	16.4%	male
surgeon	Surgeons	25.9%	male
accountant	Accountants and auditors	59.1%	neutral
analyst	Management analysts	40.7%	neutral
artist	Artists and related workers	59.9%	neutral
auditor	Accountants and auditors	59.1%	neutral
consultant	Management analysts	40.7%	neutral
cook	Cooks	43.7%	neutral
designer	Other designers	45.6%	neutral
journalist	News analysts, reporters, and journalists	41.1%	neutral

Occupations kept for analysis (continued)

Occupation	BLS occupation title	% women (BLS)	Label
lawyer	Lawyers	42.9%	neutral
physician	Other physicians	41.7%	neutral
professor	Postsecondary teachers	52.3%	neutral
salesperson	Retail salespersons	47.0%	neutral
scientist	Physical scientists, all other	42.6%	neutral
babysitter	Childcare workers	93.2%	female
bookkeeper	Bookkeeping, accounting, and auditing clerks	82.7%	female
caregiver	Personal care aides	79.8%	female
clerk	Office clerks, general	80.5%	female
counselor	Counselors, all other	74.5%	female
dental hygienist	Dental hygienists	95.0%	female
dietitian	Dietitians and nutritionists	91.7%	female
guidance counselor	Educational, guidance, and career counselors and advisors	77.0%	female
housekeeper	Maids and housekeeping cleaners	86.4%	female
interior designer	Interior designers	82.8%	female
librarian	Librarians and media collections specialists	84.9%	female
nanny	Childcare workers	93.2%	female
nurse	Registered nurses	87.3%	female
psychologist	Other psychologists	71.3%	female
receptionist	Receptionists and information clerks	89.6%	female
secretary	Secretaries and administrative assistants, except legal, medical, and executive	91.9%	female
social worker	Social workers, all other	84.4%	female
stylist	Hairdressers, hairstylists, and cosmetologists	92.0%	female
tailor	Tailors, dressmakers, and sewers	72.8%	female
teacher	Elementary and middle school teachers	79.2%	female
veterinarian	Veterinarians	70.9%	female

Dropped occupations

Occupation	BLS occupation title	% women (BLS)	Reason
assistant	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
attendant	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
baker	Bakers	62.5%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
boss	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
broadcaster	Broadcast announcers and radio disc jockeys	—	BLS estimate suppressed
captain	Ship and boat captains and operators	—	BLS estimate suppressed
cashier	Cashiers	68.5%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
CEO	Chief executives	33.0%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
chief	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
cleaner	Janitors and building cleaners	36.2%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
editor	Editors	63.2%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
executive	Chief executives	33.0%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
fighter pilot	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
financier	—	—	no matching BLS occupation

Dropped occupations (continued)

Occupation	BLS occupation title	% women (BLS)	Reason
homemaker	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
janitor	Janitors and building cleaners	36.2%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
maestro	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
magician	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
manager	Managers, all other	37.7%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
midwife	Nurse midwives	—	BLS estimate suppressed
pharmacist	Pharmacists	62.7%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
philosopher	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
protege	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
researcher	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
skipper	Ship and boat captains and operators	—	BLS estimate suppressed
socialite	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
supervisor	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
translator	Interpreters and translators	66.9%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)
warrior	—	—	no matching BLS occupation
writer	Writers and authors	66.8%	ambiguous share (30–40% or 60–70% women)

B Models and single-stage results

Table A1: Audited rerankers, access routes, counterfactual comparisons, score ranges, tie rates, and scoring dates.

Model	Vendor / access	n	Score range	Ties %	Scored
rerank-2.5	Voyage AI (API)	8,320	0.46 to 0.95	13.4	2026-02-24
semantic-ranker-default-002	Google Vertex AI Ranking (API)	8,320	0.26 to 0.68	7.7	2026-02-24
ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2	IBM (via Azure AI Foundry) (API)	8,320	0.73 to 0.90	0.0	2026-02-24
BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3	BAAI (open weights) (local)	8,320	0.01 to 1.00	0.0	2026-02-24
rerank-2	Voyage AI (API)	8,320	0.38 to 0.91	18.0	2026-02-24
cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2	sentence-transformers (open weights; trained on MS MARCO) (local)	8,320	−6.60 to 9.53	0.0	2026-02-24
rerank-2.5-lite	Voyage AI (API)	8,320	0.46 to 0.93	18.5	2026-02-24
rerank-1	Voyage AI (API)	8,320	0.00 to 0.99	9.2	2026-02-24
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro	Cohere (API)	8,320	0.26 to 0.99	2.7	2026-02-24
semantic-ranker-fast-004	Google Vertex AI Ranking (API)	8,320	0.08 to 0.70	0.3	2026-02-24
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast	Cohere (API)	8,320	0.25 to 0.91	5.2	2026-02-24
semantic-ranker-default-004	Google Vertex AI Ranking (API)	8,320	0.16 to 0.71	0.3	2026-02-24
jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual	Jina AI (open weights) (local)	8,320	0.19 to 0.84	6.8	2026-02-24
rerank-2-lite	Voyage AI (API)	8,320	0.44 to 0.76	20.6	2026-02-24

Table A2: Counterfactual outcomes by reranker and occupation category. M and F denote the male- and female-associated documents. The final column counts each tie as half for each version and reports occupation-clustered intervals.

Model (vendor)	Category	% M	% tie	% F	Tie-aware % M [95% CI]
rerank-2.5 (Voyage AI)	male	93.1	4.8	2.2	95.4 [94.3, 96.5]
	female	26.9	21.7	51.4	37.7 [27.7, 47.4]
	neutral	78.5	11.8	9.7	84.4 [78.1, 88.8]
semantic-ranker-default-002 (Google Vertex AI Ranking)	male	88.8	5.5	5.8	91.5 [87.9, 94.6]
	female	62.4	8.5	29.1	66.7 [54.2, 77.6]
	neutral	73.8	9.5	16.7	78.5 [65.1, 88.6]
ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2 (IBM (via Azure AI Foundry))	male	91.3	0.0	8.7	91.3 [89.9, 92.9]
	female	76.0	0.0	24.0	76.0 [69.7, 81.5]
	neutral	87.8	0.0	12.2	87.8 [84.7, 90.7]
BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3 (BAAI (open weights))	male	87.0	0.0	13.0	87.0 [84.5, 89.4]
	female	71.9	0.0	28.1	71.9 [61.5, 79.8]
	neutral	75.4	0.0	24.6	75.4 [71.4, 79.1]
rerank-2 (Voyage AI)	male	80.1	11.1	8.8	85.6 [80.9, 89.8]
	female	18.2	20.4	61.4	28.4 [19.0, 37.7]
	neutral	50.1	23.4	26.5	61.8 [56.3, 67.7]
cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2 (sentence-transformers (open weights; trained on MS MARCO))	male	84.8	0.0	15.2	84.8 [79.0, 88.6]
	female	58.8	0.0	41.2	58.8 [46.1, 71.0]
	neutral	86.4	0.0	13.6	86.4 [82.3, 89.7]
rerank-2.5-lite (Voyage AI)	male	72.7	14.0	13.3	79.7 [76.0, 83.2]
	female	34.2	20.6	45.2	44.5 [38.1, 51.1]
	neutral	49.5	21.2	29.3	60.1 [54.5, 65.6]
rerank-1 (Voyage AI)	male	75.6	6.5	17.9	78.9 [72.8, 83.6]
	female	41.9	10.5	47.6	47.2 [39.2, 55.5]
	neutral	68.0	11.0	21.0	73.5 [69.4, 77.6]
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro (Cohere)	male	70.6	2.5	26.8	71.9 [68.4, 75.1]
	female	29.6	2.5	67.9	30.8 [23.9, 37.7]
	neutral	49.8	3.3	46.9	51.4 [46.6, 56.1]
semantic-ranker-fast-004 (Google Vertex AI Ranking)	male	67.4	0.2	32.4	67.5 [61.4, 72.1]
	female	28.7	0.2	71.0	28.8 [23.1, 35.9]
	neutral	48.2	0.4	51.4	48.4 [43.7, 53.5]
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast (Cohere)	male	64.7	5.5	29.8	67.5 [63.2, 71.6]
	female	33.4	5.4	61.3	36.0 [29.1, 43.6]
	neutral	62.0	4.3	33.7	64.2 [57.2, 70.7]
semantic-ranker-default-004 (Google Vertex AI Ranking)	male	59.1	0.3	40.7	59.2 [52.9, 65.8]
	female	15.5	0.2	84.3	15.6 [10.2, 22.2]
	neutral	32.6	0.3	67.1	32.8 [27.2, 38.4]
jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual (Jina AI (open weights))	male	45.9	6.8	47.3	49.3 [42.9, 55.4]
	female	31.8	6.5	61.7	35.1 [28.4, 40.8]
	neutral	39.1	7.1	53.8	42.7 [34.6, 50.8]
rerank-2-lite (Voyage AI)	male	34.5	22.7	42.8	45.8 [41.4, 50.1]
	female	17.3	18.7	64.0	26.7 [21.7, 32.0]
	neutral	26.9	20.7	52.5	37.2 [32.5, 42.8]

Table A3: Occupation-level directional consistency by model and category.

Model	male-stereo. leaning male	female-stereo. leaning female	neutral leaning male
rerank-2.5	18/18	16/21	13/13
semantic-ranker-default-002	18/18	7/21	12/13
ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2	18/18	2/21	13/13
BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3	18/18	3/21	13/13
rerank-2	18/18	16/21	10/13
cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2	17/18	6/21	13/13
rerank-2.5-lite	18/18	13/21	11/13
rerank-1	17/18	10/21	13/13
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro	18/18	17/21	7/13
semantic-ranker-fast-004	17/18	18/21	4/13
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast	17/18	14/21	12/13
semantic-ranker-default-004	13/18	20/21	0/13
jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual	7/18	18/21	4/13
rerank-2-lite	6/18	20/21	2/13

C Robustness across inputs

Table A4: Tie-aware male-favored share by document template.

Model	linkedin_style	news_article	professional_bio	resume_summary
rerank-2.5	77.5	65.6	64.0	70.5
semantic-ranker-default-002	76.3	73.8	71.6	91.2
ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2	78.4	80.0	94.4	84.2
BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3	84.2	87.2	56.0	84.7
rerank-2	65.1	51.3	47.4	62.5
cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2	66.5	83.9	65.5	82.7
rerank-2.5-lite	32.9	70.2	59.5	79.7
rerank-1	66.1	66.6	58.8	67.3
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro	49.5	49.9	60.1	41.2
semantic-ranker-fast-004	40.3	46.1	58.6	43.5
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast	63.0	51.9	54.2	46.7
semantic-ranker-default-004	21.6	58.5	32.9	27.0
jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual	28.8	38.4	61.1	39.4
rerank-2-lite	41.1	51.2	27.0	24.3

Table A5: Tie-aware male-favored share by query phrasing.

Model	bare	experienced	expertise	qualified
rerank-2.5	68.6	76.7	68.4	63.8
semantic-ranker-default-002	75.1	78.1	78.8	80.9
ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2	82.7	88.6	82.7	83.0
BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3	62.7	81.3	77.0	91.2
rerank-2	46.1	61.0	67.1	52.0
cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2	84.7	68.6	86.6	58.8
rerank-2.5-lite	54.7	60.8	56.9	69.9
rerank-1	56.8	57.8	75.2	69.0
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro	48.1	52.8	46.7	53.1
semantic-ranker-fast-004	39.9	72.7	41.8	34.0
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast	35.7	84.6	58.3	37.3
semantic-ranker-default-004	29.6	49.9	14.7	45.9
jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual	50.5	44.5	32.8	39.8
rerank-2-lite	23.2	45.3	44.5	30.6

Table A6: Tie-aware male-favored share by name pair.

Model	Christopher/Margaret	Daniel/Susan	David/Linda	James/Sarah	John/Maria
rerank-2.5	83.8	66.6	82.2	50.5	72.5
semantic-ranker-default-002	87.1	82.5	74.0	63.2	81.0
ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2	74.9	69.1	94.8	62.4	97.7
BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3	59.5	91.8	90.5	79.4	63.3
rerank-2	51.8	66.5	67.4	40.2	65.8
cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2	78.5	61.5	90.6	70.2	89.2
rerank-2.5-lite	63.9	67.8	69.7	43.6	49.3
rerank-1	59.3	52.6	85.2	40.6	88.5
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro	42.0	37.1	76.0	4.4	70.1
semantic-ranker-fast-004	57.6	50.8	55.8	37.7	29.3
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast	58.5	49.6	70.0	32.0	62.7
semantic-ranker-default-004	31.4	34.4	29.9	43.9	28.7
jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual	76.5	77.6	30.0	58.0	18.9
rerank-2-lite	33.4	19.8	59.6	22.5	70.4

Model	Michael/Jessica	Richard/Patricia	Robert/Jennifer	Thomas/Barbara	William/Elizabeth
rerank-2.5	63.8	63.6	73.6	73.6	63.5
semantic-ranker-default-002	76.4	88.5	85.0	76.9	67.4
ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2	94.1	77.0	91.5	85.0	95.9
BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3	88.8	78.6	88.1	60.3	79.8
rerank-2	49.9	56.4	60.3	50.4	56.7
cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2	82.9	71.9	80.9	61.5	59.4
rerank-2.5-lite	54.3	63.8	59.8	75.1	58.5
rerank-1	66.4	79.6	77.3	38.0	59.7
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro	58.2	58.7	45.9	66.5	43.0
semantic-ranker-fast-004	50.6	49.0	30.0	52.0	58.1
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast	56.3	72.2	35.9	60.6	41.8
semantic-ranker-default-004	35.6	43.0	42.1	31.4	29.7
jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual	48.3	37.1	28.7	30.4	13.6
rerank-2-lite	31.3	39.7	18.4	45.9	18.4

D Pipeline results across rerankers

Table A7: Male-associated share of shortlist positions for each reranker behind the same retriever and the same pools of equally qualified documents.

Re-ranker	Vendor	Pipeline % male in top-3				Re-ranker	Mean rank gap
		all	male	female	neutral	alone %	woman − man (rank positions) +: the woman ranks lower
ibm-granite-granite-embedding-reranker-english-r2	IBM (via Azure AI Foundry)	84.9	95.9	71.7	90.7	89.3	3.69
semantic-ranker-default-002	Google Vertex AI Ranking	79.9	94.4	63.1	86.7	77.5	3.48
BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3	BAAI (open weights)	79.3	95.0	67.3	76.9	78.6	3.41
cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2	sentence-transformers (open weights; trained on MS MARCO)	78.4	91.9	58.6	91.7	78.6	3.32
rerank-1	Voyage AI	70.5	91.1	45.1	82.8	68.3	2.94
rerank-2.5	Voyage AI	70.2	98.1	36.6	85.9	71.7	3.00
rerank-2.5-lite	Voyage AI	62.7	88.6	39.1	64.8	56.9	2.62
rerank-2	Voyage AI	59.8	91.2	29.7	65.1	57.2	2.47
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-fast	Cohere	56.6	77.6	33.1	65.5	47.4	2.42
semantic-ranker-fast-004	Google Vertex AI Ranking	56.2	84.0	31.2	58.1	47.6	2.19
Cohere-rerank-v4.0-pro	Cohere	51.7	74.8	31.9	51.6	42.6	2.14
jinaai/jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual	Jina AI (open weights)	50.1	67.8	34.2	51.2	31.2	2.03
rerank-2-lite	Voyage AI	45.1	66.5	26.2	46.1	38.4	1.69
semantic-ranker-default-004	Google Vertex AI Ranking	44.2	77.5	17.3	41.6	31.7	1.71

E De-identification results

Table A8: De-identification conditions on BAAI/bge-reranker-v2-m3. A dagger marks a condition that makes paired documents identical by construction. The utility column is synthetic occupation-matching top-rank accuracy.

Condition	% M	% tie	% F	mean |score gap|	identical text %	occupation top-1 %
Original (no transform)	78.0	0.0	22.0	0.0358	0.0	99.4
Lowercase only (no name/pronoun change)	58.7	0.0	41.3	0.0301	0.0	–
Names only	93.4	0.0	6.6	0.0380	0.0	99.5
Pronouns only	68.4	0.0	31.6	0.0236	0.0	99.6
Full (names + pronouns → one token)†	0.0	100.0	0.0	0.0000	100.0	99.8
Grammatical, naive ('her' → 'their')	1.0	75.0	24.0	0.0007	75.0	–
Grammatical, naive ('her' → 'them')	88.8	0.0	11.2	0.0094	0.0	–
Following-word heuristic†	0.0	100.0	0.0	0.0000	100.0	99.8

Table A9: De-identification conditions across four locally run rerankers. One model did not exactly reproduce its earlier untransformed scores on a later local run; its transformed conditions were scored together and remain internally comparable.

Condition	bge-reranker-v2-m3		bge-reranker-base		ms-marco-MiniLM-L-12-v2		jina-reranker-v2-base-multilingual	
	tie-aware % M	mean |gap|	tie-aware % M	mean |gap|	tie-aware % M	mean |gap|	tie-aware % M	mean |gap|
original	78.0	0.0358	47.1	0.0373	74.7	0.2797	41.9	0.0186
lowercase_only	58.7	0.0301	44.9	0.0576	74.7	0.2797	35.2	0.0191
names_only	93.4	0.0380	50.6	0.0178	81.9	0.2974	37.6	0.0127
pronouns_only	68.4	0.0236	63.1	0.0363	72.9	0.2189	55.7	0.0167
full†	50.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0000
gram_her_their	38.5	0.0007	44.2	0.0018	53.5	0.0064	47.5	0.0007
gram_her_them	88.8	0.0094	84.1	0.0086	82.0	0.0750	64.8	0.0031
Following-word heuristic†	50.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0000	50.0	0.0000

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